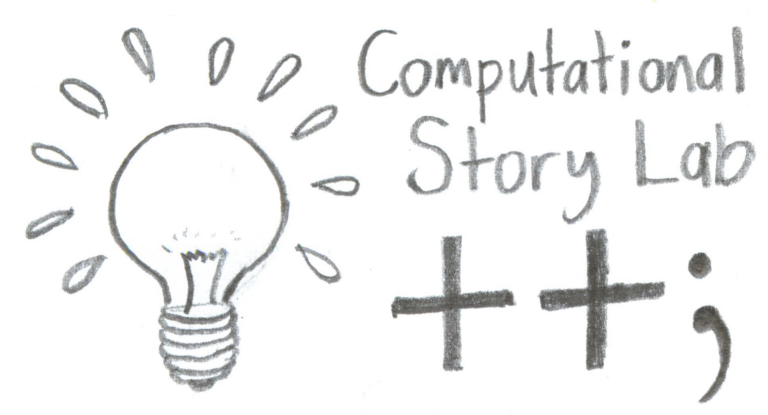
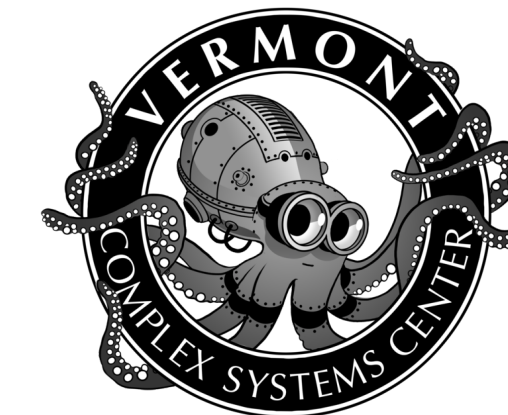


False memories to fake news: The evolution of the term “misinformation” in academic literature

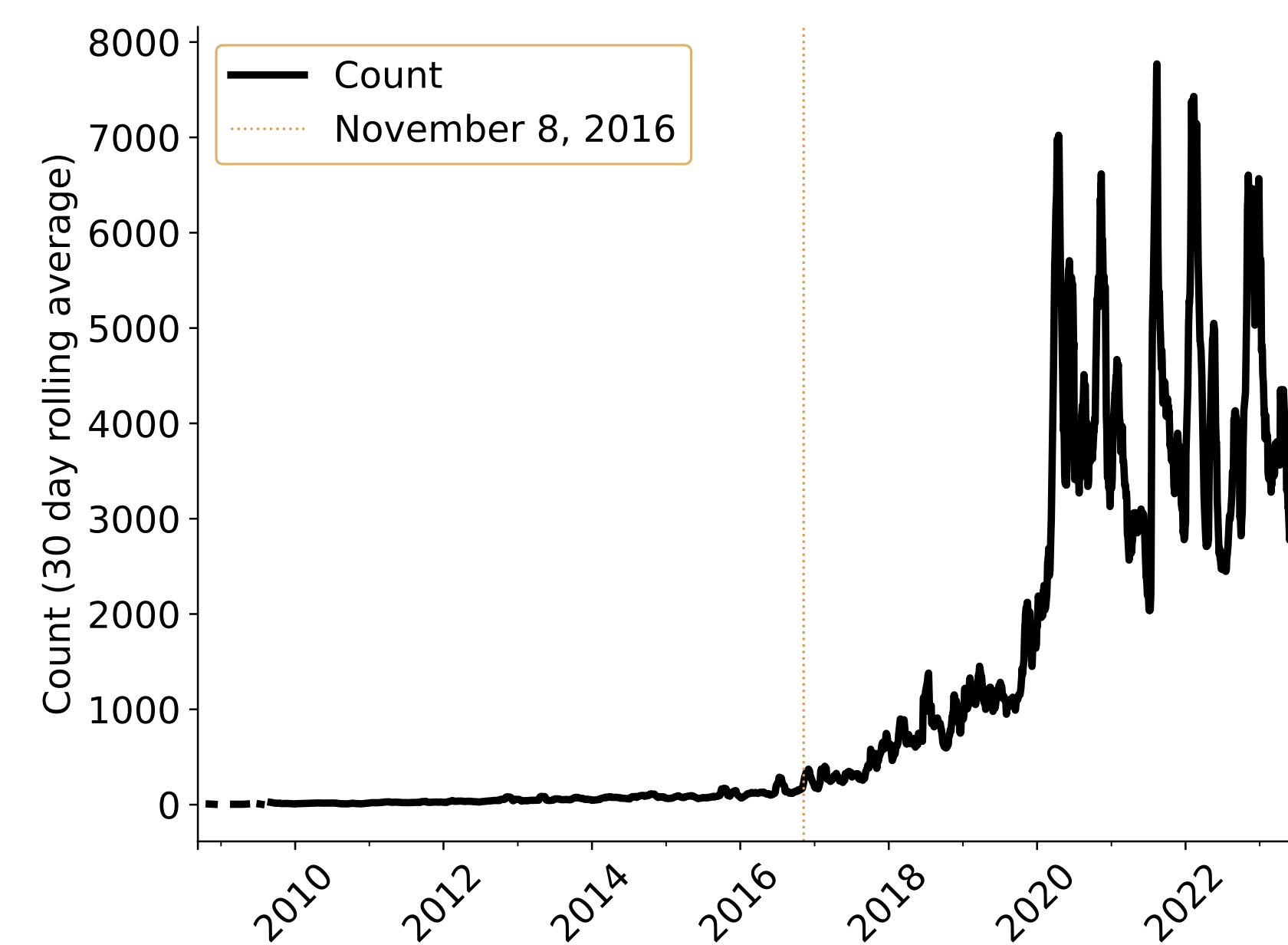


Alejandro Ruiz, Danny Benett, Julia Zimmerman, Christopher M. Danforth, Peter Sheridan Dodds

Computational Story Lab, Vermont Complex System Center



Twitter usage of “misinformation”



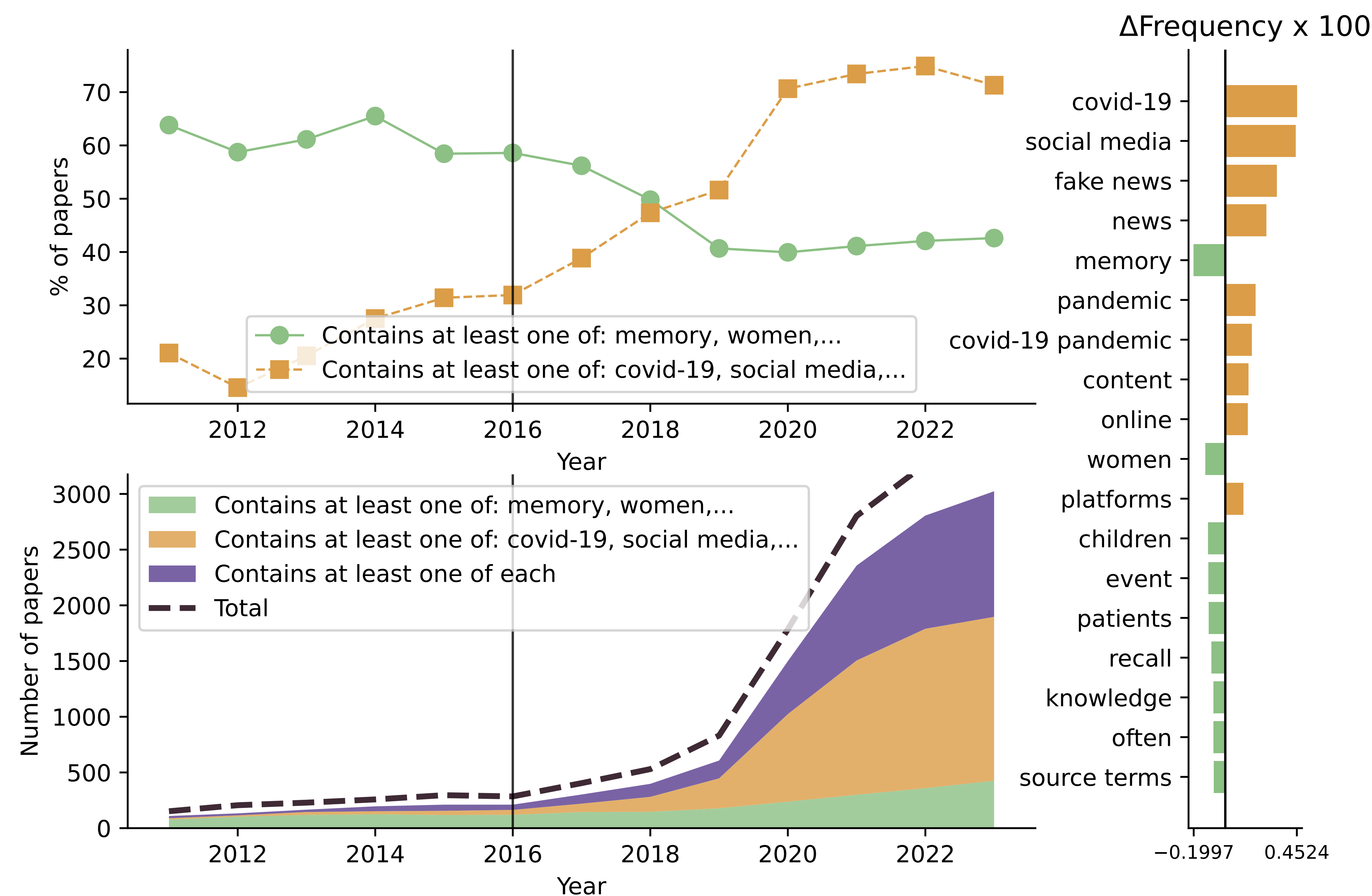
In academic literature

- 1956: "Combating Food Misinformation and Quackery"
- 1957: "Information and Misinformation Gained from Fasting Blood Sugar Alone in Diabetes Therapy"
- 1970: "A Model of the Soviet Firm"
 - Soviet firms' attempts to correct for “systematic misinformation” by changing incentives
- 1974: "Reconstruction of automobile destruction: An example of the interaction between language and memory"
 - Introduces the 'misinformation effect'
- 1989: "Categorical Approach to Distributed Systems, Expressibility and Knowledge [...] the adversary should be chosen not to send identical faulty messages but to 'convey' the same misinformation"
- 2002: "Infodemiology: The Epidemiology of (Mis)Information"
 - "The study of the determinants and distribution of health information and misinformation"
 - 2007–2010 - Infodemiology extends to study how (mis)information spreads during crises (earthquakes, epidemics, etc.) on social media
- 2016: The post-2016 paradigm is born

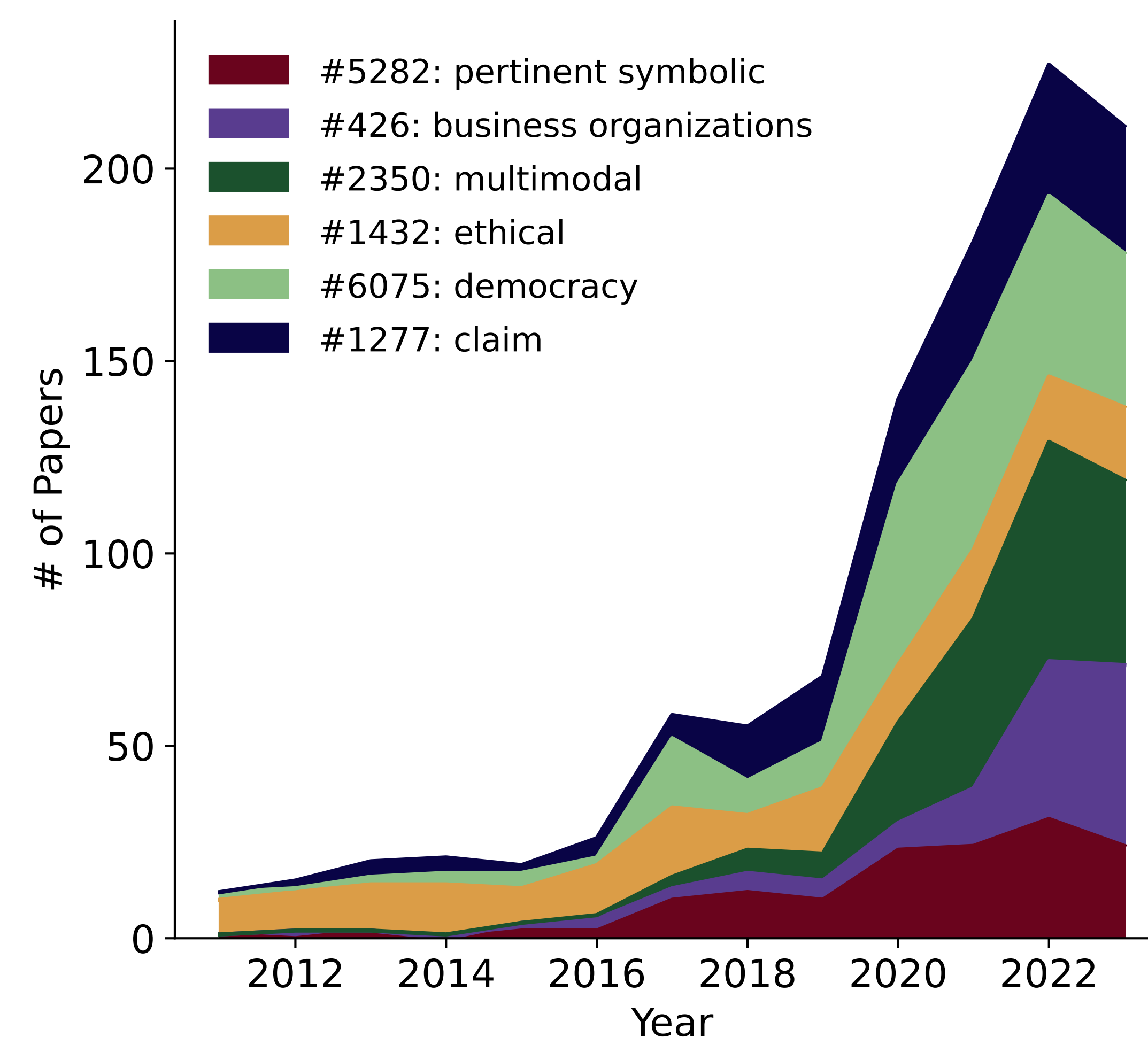
“Misinformation effect” and the Satanic panic

- The misinformation effect refers to the susceptibility of memories of an event to change when exposed to, for example, misleading questions
- The Satanic panic enters the mainstream with *Michelle Remembers*, in which a recovered-memory patient and her doctor/soon-to-be-husband recount her (fabricated) childhood of torture by a Satanic cult

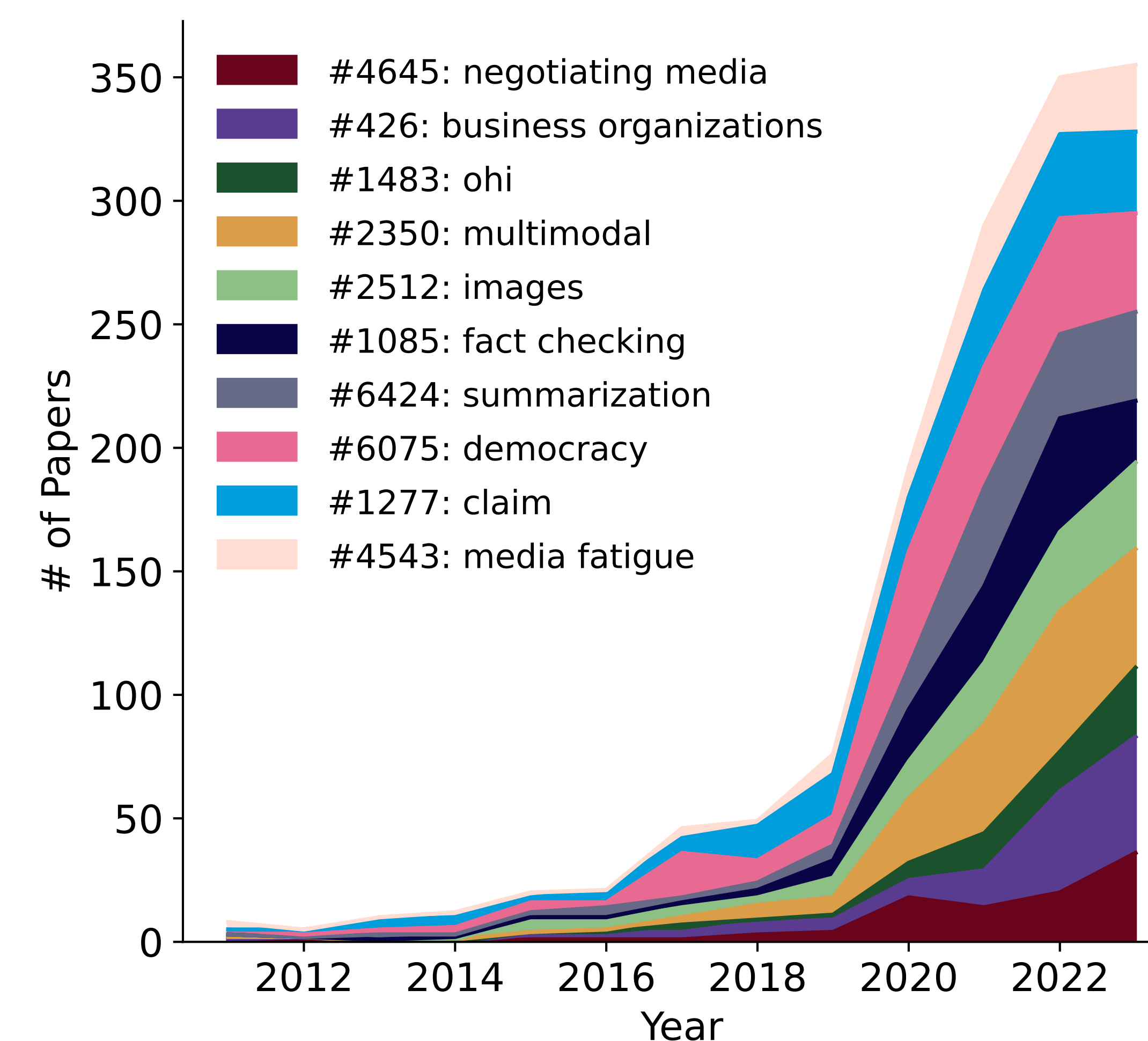
The **misinformation paradigm** studies people making, reading, and sharing **false statements**, usually on **social media**. It often produces research warning of the harm to society resulting from the sum of many such events.



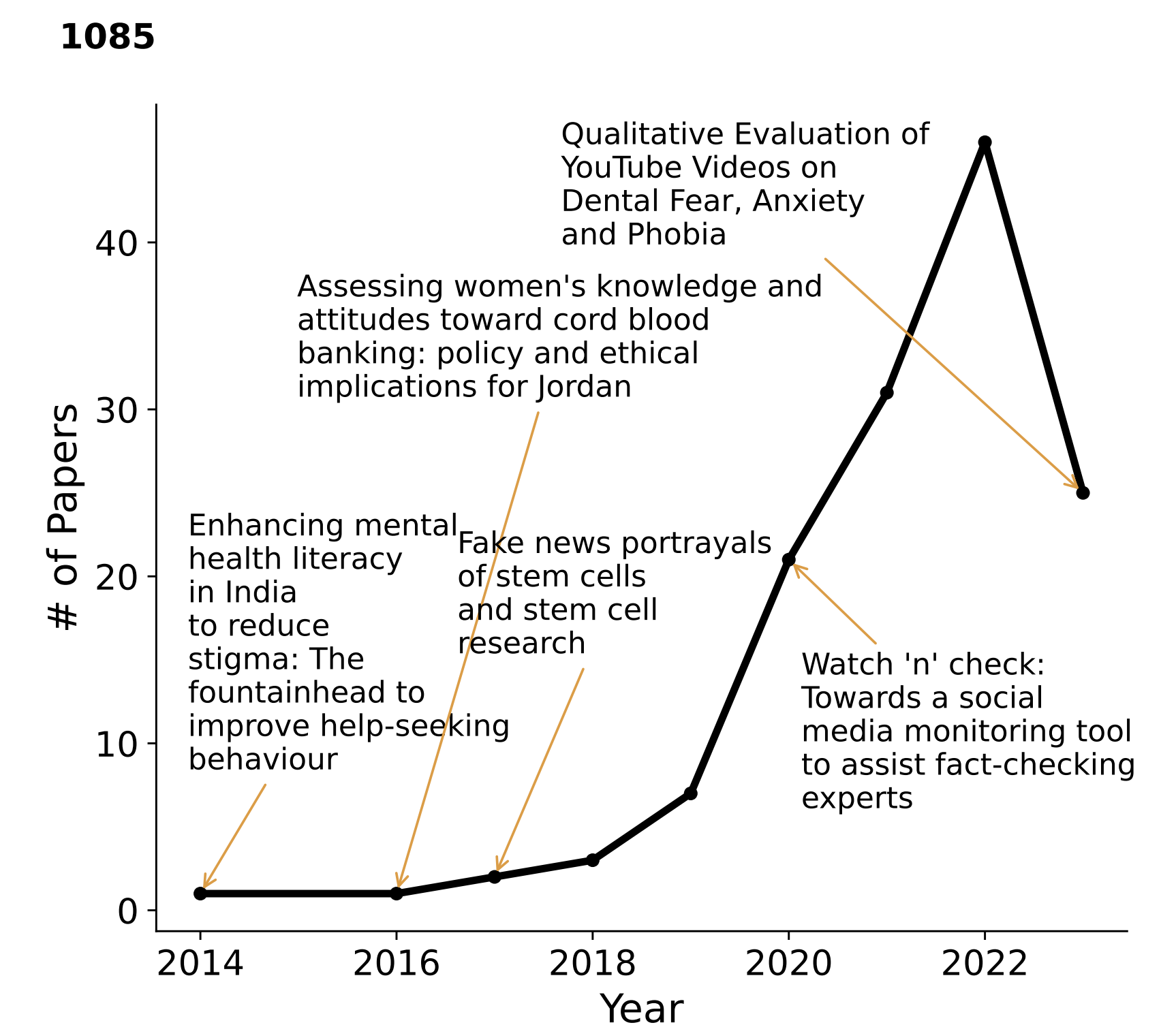
a) Top 2 communities of each year



b) Top 10 communities of 2023



Birth of the post-2016 paradigm



Theoretical Problems

- **No theory of medium:** Misinformation paradigm sees through the medium, often discussing **direct** user interaction
- **Zombie laboratory model:** The core model from misinformation effect research is detached from its real world phenomenon
- **Lack of emergent theory:** Paradigm contains untenable theoretical commitment to evaluating individual pieces of information

Lack of emergent theory

- Researchers often define misinformation as social media posts that includes links to known unreliable sources
- Public relations, military propaganda, intelligence agencies, etc. operate in the chasm between true and false, rather than at its poles
- The more likely that a piece of misinformation is to be believed, the more difficult it necessarily is to detect as misinformation
- Untenable theoretical commitments force misinformation scholars to focus their inquiry precisely on the least salient part of the phenomenon